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CHAPTER 1

Stitch's Grin in the Empty Room

The VHS static starts like a throat clearing - thin, grainy, impatient - then thickens into a dark, wet hush as the camera's view tilts toward a living room that doesn't know what shape it's supposed to be. Furniture sits wrong. The couch is there, but its seams look melted, sagging into the carpet like tired wax. A coffee table stretches too long by a few inches each time the noise spikes, as if the room is breathing through the screen.

Mara stands inside it anyway, palms flat against the wall because her body needs something solid to negotiate with. The wallpaper peels in slow curls, then reforms when the static stutters. Cold light leaks from nowhere, turning dust into glitter that never settles. Somewhere behind her, the faint childlike melody of Aloha ʻŌe warps under the hum - notes skipping like a tape caught on a tooth.

And then Stitch is there.

Not on a TV. Not in a reflection. Stitch stands alone in the middle of the empty room, small and bright against the dark, his grin stretched just a little too wide for cartoon logic. His stitched muzzle looks clean for a moment - then the threads blur, as if someone smudged him with a thumb. He tilts his head toward Mara like he's listening. His eyes catch the camera's angle, and the grin answers it, widening with each glitchy pulse of static.

Mara's throat tightens. She doesn't remember choosing this. She remembers reaching for something - any exit, any seam in the distortion - and the tape's audio yanking her attention like a hook through cloth.

"Stop," she says, voice scraping. The word sounds muffled, swallowed by the room's wrongness.

Stitch doesn't move fast. He doesn't need to. He lifts a hand - slow, jerky, cartoon-real at the same time - and waves as if greeting an audience. The motion stutters mid-air, then completes itself with a half-beat delay, like the tape is deciding what's allowed to happen.

Mara turns toward the door she can almost see.

It's there on the far wall, a dark rectangle framed by warped trim. The farther she stares, the more the edges ripple, as if the doorway is a screen inside the screen. She takes one step, feeling the floor under her shoes tighten like rubber. Another step - her shoulders brush the edge of a curtain that shouldn't be there, only it's not cloth. It's thread. It slides along her arm and leaves faint, tacky lines of gray behind.

The room is trying to keep her inside.

The warped Aloha 𐀀 tugs again, looping a phrase that shouldn't repeat so insistently. The melody isn't clear enough to sing along with. It's clear enough to lock onto. Every time Mara shifts her feet, the audio shifts with her, as if it's mapping her position and correcting it. Her ears pop with the static, and the sound pulls at her balance until the coffee table - stretching, retracting - blocks the path by a few inches.

Mara swears under her breath. She forces her gaze forward, toward the door. Orientation is the only weapon she has left. She keeps her eyes on the frame, on the thin bright line where the darkness should end, and she moves with quick, measured steps like she's walking through a bad video feed that might correct itself if she doesn't flinch.

Stitch's grin follows her.

He stays in the middle distance, but the camera angle keeps tightening, like the tape wants a closer view. Stitch's silhouette sharpens during the louder spikes of static,

then blurs again when the audio lowers. His laughter - faint, childlike, wrong - threads through the hum, synced to the melody's broken rhythm.

"You're not - " Mara starts, then stops because the sentence doesn't know what it's accusing. Stitch? The tape? The room?

The laugh stretches wider, and Stitch takes a step that makes the carpet ripple under Mara's feet. It's not a sound effect. It's a physical disturbance, a subtle tilt in the world. The living room's corners pull inward, as if the walls are leaning to listen.

Mara reaches for the door handle.

Her fingers find metal cold enough to bite. She curls her hand around it - solid, real, blessedly unwarped for a breath - and pulls.

The handle doesn't give. Instead, the doorframe warps with a soft shiver, like a VHS image being re-centered. The opening narrows, not by moving closer, but by changing what it's made of. The trim buckles, melting into a smooth gray strip that slides across the gap and seals it shut.

Mara yanks again, harder. The metal vibrates in her grip. The warped Aloha 𐀀 rises, too cheerful under the distortion, and a crackle of static blooms into something like a voice caught between channels.

" - Oe - " the audio says, syllables misfiring. The rest becomes a smear of sound that still feels like instruction.

Mara jerks her hand back. A faint gray smudge clings to her skin, like lint from old film. The room temperature dips. Her breath fogs and then disappears too quickly, as if the air doesn't want to linger.

Stitch moves closer now, one step at a time, each movement delayed by a fraction. He's not rushing. He's pacing, like he has all day and the tape is the clock. When he lifts his head, his stitched grin seems to widen by itself, the curve stretching past where it should be.

Mara swallows. "I'm leaving."

Stitch's reply is a glitch.

For a second, his face fills more of the room than it should, like the camera is zooming without anyone touching the lens. His eyes flicker between cartoon-black and something too lifelike to be part of the drawing. His mouth opens, and the audio track warps so hard the Aloha Æ becomes a grinding, cheerful hiss. He doesn't speak words - only laughter, then the sound of a tape tearing.

Mara flinches back from the door, but her heel catches on something that wasn't there a moment ago: the edge of a rug that's become thicker, darker, and slightly sticky. She stumbles, grabs for the couch to steady herself, and the couch skin yields under her fingers like warm plastic.

"Okay," she says, because her voice needs to anchor her. "Okay. Orientation."

She forces herself up and looks for landmarks. The couch. The warped coffee table. The doorway. Stitch.

She tries to reposition - side step, angle toward the right wall, find a different path out. As she moves, the warped song follows like a leash. The melody jumps to match her steps, re-locking her position with every glitch. When she turns her head, she sees the coffee table sliding into her line of sight again, as if the room remembers where she's supposed to be.

Mara's lungs burn. She takes a faster step, refusing the correction. The floor answers with a tremor. The rug edge flips under her shoe - one moment it's underfoot, the next it's behind her - like the tape is rewinding her feet without rewinding her body.

She goes down hard. Her shoulder hits the floor, and the impact feels damp, as if the carpet is soaked in shadow. Pain flashes white-hot, then dulls into a numb ache that doesn't feel quite right, like the sensation is being averaged out by the static.

Stitch appears nearer than he should be.

His grin is close enough that Mara can see the faint fuzz of his fur melting at the edges, threads loosening as the image glitches. His eyes are fixed on her hands, on the smear of gray she dragged along the floor. He leans in, and his laughter turns into a low, rhythmic hum that matches the tape's static.

Mara pushes herself upright, teeth clenched. "Don't - "

A new glitch cracks the room open.

The ceiling light flickers, and for half a second the living room looks normal - just normal enough to be cruel. The couch sits properly. The coffee table stops stretching. The doorway stands as a doorway again, dark and waiting. Mara's hope sparks bright and immediate, and she reaches for it before the tape can think.

Her fingers hit the door handle.

This time it's warm, like someone has been holding it. The metal hums faintly under her touch, and the Aloha 𐤎Oe becomes clearer, almost sweet, almost human. Mara braces her body and yanks.

The door swings inward.

Cold air - real, sharp air - rushes across her face. The gap beyond is only darkness, but it's the kind of darkness that has distance in it. Mara steps through, one foot, then the other, and the sensation of leaving the room is unmistakable for a heartbeat.

Then the warped audio spikes.

The melody stutters. The static thickens. Stitch laughs from behind her, and the sound isn't just heard - it's projected, layered, as if the tape is stamping his presence onto her exit.

Mara turns her head to look back.

Stitch stands in the living room doorway she just crossed, grinning like he's been waiting there the whole time. His face fills the frame for a second, too close, too

detailed, threads of fur pixelating into something jagged. His open mouth stretches wider than his body should allow, and in the glitchy zoom the teeth aren't cartoon teeth anymore - rows of jagged shapes, wrong in number and spacing, like a mouth made from cut film frames.

Mara's stomach drops.

She pulls her arm toward the darkness beyond, trying to grab the doorway's edge before it changes its mind. The air beyond the threshold suddenly feels thicker, as if the space is being compressed. Her fingers snag on nothing - just a smooth, gray surface that wasn't there before.

The door behind her snaps shut with a soft, wet sound.

No slam. No impact. Just a quiet correction, like the tape has re-centered her. The living room returns around her in a shiver, furniture warping back into place with that slow melting ease. The coffee table slides a few inches closer. The rug curls at the edges. The doorway becomes a sealed rectangle again, trim rippling like it's trying to remember how to be flat.

Mara stands in the distorted room, breathing hard, shoulder throbbing. The gray smudge on her skin has spread, thin as ash.

Stitch watches from the middle distance.

The Aloha    resumes its warped loop, and the static hum lowers into something almost conversational. Mara feels the audio tug at her again - not like a sound effect now, but like a force that wants her to settle into the tape's intended position. Her eyes want to follow the door. Her body wants to step back - back to where it was before the exit, back to the center of the distortion.

She clenches her jaw and tries to fight it.

She takes one step toward the camera angle - toward where Stitch appears to be framed - because if the tape is locking her position, maybe she can break the pattern

by changing the rule. Maybe the camera's idea of "center" can be exploited. Maybe the room's wrongness has a seam she can widen.

The second her foot moves, the audio locks again.

The warped melody stutters into a sharper pitch, and the room responds like it's obeying a command. The coffee table shifts into her path. The couch edge crawls toward her hip. The rug flips under her shoe, correcting her stumble so she lands - again - facing the sealed door.

Mara's hand shoots out to steady herself on the coffee table.

The surface is cold and soft at the same time, like plastic wrapped around ice. Her palm leaves a faint print that fades and then reappears, like the tape can't decide whether to remember her touch. She jerks her hand away, and as the static spikes, Stitch's grin widens in the dark.

His laughter grows louder, closer, and for a moment the room seems to tilt toward the camera as if the lens is inside him.

Mara reaches for the door again anyway. She presses her fingers against the trim, feeling it ripple under her skin. The warped Aloha 𐀀 swells, and the static becomes a tight, buzzing roar.

Then the screen glitches.

Not outside her - inside her. The air ripples like a VHS frame being rewound. The world she's standing in shifts with a sickening ease, furniture sliding, walls stretching, the doorway sliding away from her hand as if the tape is dragging her back into its own image.

Mara's body jerks sideways, caught by the correction.

Her fingers scrape the sealed trim and find nothing. She spins, trying to catch where the doorway went, but the room re-centers with a wet, quiet snap. The door is gone

from reach. The living room is back in its distorted arrangement. Stitch stands alone in the dark, smiling like the tape has won.

Mara stares at the place where her hand just was, skin tingling with that gray residue.

The warped Aloha 𐀀 loops one more time - cheerful, broken, relentless - and Stitch's grin holds, widening with each glitch until his face feels too big for the room. The static hum rises to swallow the sound of her breathing.

Mara lunges toward the doorframe one last time.

The screen glitches.

For a blink, she's inside the tape again, repositioned without consent, the sealed doorway now inches away from where her hand used to be - close enough to tempt, far enough to keep her trapped.

CHAPTER 2



Carousel Toys That Won't Stay Put

The carpet under her palm wasn't carpet anymore. It was slick wood, cold at first, then dampening as her skin registered the wrongness - like she'd stepped barefoot onto something that had been wet for a long time and only pretended to dry. Mara jerked her hand back and felt the air tear with a hiss of static, the sound too close to be coming from the room. The doorway behind her - sealed, inch-wide, tempting - stood where it shouldn't, a thin vertical slice of light that pulsed like a heartbeat caught on tape.

Somewhere in the dark, Stitch laughed.

Not the bright, cartoon sound she'd been trying to pretend she didn't recognize. This was closer to paper being crumpled, breathy and wrong, threaded with a rhythm that didn't belong to empty rooms. The laugh repeated in intervals, skipping like the tape itself was searching for a place to land. Mara's throat tightened. She pressed her ear toward the sound, because panic made her stupid and because the static had already trained her hands to follow what her mind tried to refuse.

The playground - she could feel it in the way the air cooled, in the faint chemical smell of old metal and sweet plastic - came into focus in pieces. A swing set silhouette. A slide with its paint flaking like sunburn. The carousel's low ring, just beyond reach. But the world wouldn't hold still long enough to be trusted. The light flickered in her peripheral vision, and every flicker made the doorway's slice of brightness shift a few inches farther away, like the tape was dragging it on a string.

Mara wanted the door. Wanted it the way you wanted a heartbeat to stop when it was threatening to keep going forever. Her fingers curled around nothing, searching for a

latch that wasn't there. She tried to remember the last time she'd moved with intention instead of reacting - what she'd done, what she'd decided. The static answered her thoughts with a wet thump, and Stitch's laughter sharpened, as if she'd proven she could hear it.

"Stop," she said, but the word came out thin, caught between her teeth. Her voice sounded muffled, like it was traveling through a screen.

The laugh didn't stop. It slid sideways on the sound wave, leading her - no, pulling her - toward the carousel.

Mara took a step. The ground gave under her shoe, not soft like sand, but springy, as if the entire playground was a stretched membrane waiting to snap back. She forced herself forward anyway, because hesitation was how the tape had trapped her before. The carousel ring came closer, and she saw the animals without getting to decide whether she wanted to.

They were wrong in a way that made her stomach flip. Painted faces stretched too far, smiles too wide, wood grain that seemed to twist like muscle under skin. One horse had a neck that ended too cleanly, as if someone had cut it with scissors and then taped over the gap with darkness. Another animal's eyes were hollow sockets that caught the flickering light and threw it back at her in dull, dead reflections.

Stitch's laughter echoed behind the carousel, but when she turned her head, there was nothing but empty space and static. The laughter wasn't coming from a direction like sound should. It was coming from a pattern. It was telling her where the tape wanted her body to go.

Mara swallowed. The air tasted like pennies and old rain. Her palms were slick. She wiped one hand on her jeans and left a smear that looked like soot. That shouldn't have happened. Nothing here should have left marks on her clothes. She stared at the black smear until the smear shivered, then re-set itself - like the tape had edited out the evidence.

She pressed her fingers to her own wrist, grounding herself in pulse. It was fast. Too fast. If she didn't move, she might start listening to the static instead of using her own ears.

She stepped around the carousel ring. The wooden floorboards beneath her shoes started to hum, a low vibration that made her teeth feel loose. The carousel didn't spin, not yet. It waited, stationary like a trap that hadn't decided to snap. Mara kept her eyes on Stitch's laughter, on the way it repeated, on the cadence that felt like a countdown she couldn't see.

Then the carousel began to move.

Not smoothly. It jerked, starting and stopping in stuttering frames, as if someone was scrubbing through a VHS recording with impatient fingers. The horses rotated a fraction of a turn and then jerked back. The hollow-eyed animal's head tilted farther than it should have, and for a split second Mara saw something that wasn't paint - something darker underneath, like a shadow trapped inside the wood.

She flinched, and the laughter cut out.

Silence hit so hard her ears rang.

In that sudden absence, the playground's sounds - windless air, distant hum, the faint creak of plastic - felt like they'd been turned off. Mara's breath sounded too loud. She looked for Stitch, half expecting to see him in the dark like he'd been in the earlier tape frames, alone and grinning, eyes flickering between too-real and too-animated.

No Stitch. Just static, thickening again, rolling in from the edges of her vision.

The sealed doorway wasn't behind her anymore. It was to her left, a thin slice of light between two carousel posts that hadn't been there a moment ago. The tape had repositioned her without asking, again. Mara turned in a sharp arc, heart slamming, and her hand swept through air that smelled like hot dust.

She didn't know where she was facing. She didn't know which direction counted as forward.

Stitch's laughter returned, but softer now, almost playful. It sounded like it was behind her shoulder even when her head turned. Mara realized with a sick clarity that she'd been treating the laugh like a compass. She'd assumed it was information, a signal. But fear made her misread things - fear made her chase patterns instead of choices.

The carousel light - faint, flickering - stuttered brighter. The wooden animals blurred as if the tape was about to tear them away from the world. Mara tightened her grip on her own sleeve and forced her feet to move anyway, not toward the slice of doorway, not toward the laugh, but toward the only stable thing she could feel: the ground's slight vibration, consistent like a conveyor belt's hum.

She walked faster. Her shoes slapped the boards in uneven rhythm, and the sound of her movement seemed to interfere with the static, like the tape hated being interrupted by real footsteps. The carousel's ring shuddered behind her, and she heard something else creep into the audio layer - metal, distant and rhythmic, sliding in under the laughter.

A factory smell replaced the playground's plastic-sweet air. Oil. Warm dust. Something sharp like burned wires. The temperature dropped around her ankles. The sky above the playground dimmed, then went away entirely, swallowed by a ceiling that wasn't there a heartbeat ago.

The world warped - frame by frame - into a corridor lit by conveyor lights that blinked in sync with the tape's glitches. Mara stumbled forward and caught herself on the nearest surface, and her palm met cold metal ribbing instead of wood. The floor was no longer boards; it was a grated belt that moved under her weight, shifting her stance like the ground had decided to become machinery.

Stitch's laughter turned into a background track she couldn't drown out, layered under the conveyor's steady grind. It didn't guide her anymore. It watched her through the wrong kind of noise.

Mara looked back.

The carousel was gone. Not just out of sight - edited out. In its place, a factory wall rose where the swing set should have been, seams and panels too clean to belong in a playground. The thin slice of doorway of light was there too, but now it hovered above the belt like a sign, flickering with the same pulse as the VHS static.

Her stomach dropped. She'd moved past the carousel. She'd done what she thought mattered. And the tape had rewarded her with a tighter cage.

A metal clatter echoed down the corridor, followed by a low, intermittent clicking that made her skin crawl. The conveyor lights ahead blinked through the same three colors - dim, dimmer, gone - then returned, as if someone was testing whether she could see in the dark.

Mara's breath came out in short bursts. She tried to decide whether to run toward the light or away from it. The laughter seemed to swell when she considered turning back, as if Stitch wanted her direction set by her doubt.

"You're not... you're not sound," she whispered, and her voice shook on the last word.

The static answered with a brief, warped fragment - something like a child's song caught between frames, stretched thin and wrong. It didn't fully resolve into any recognizable tune, but the cadence was there, the way the tape had dragged Aloha into her earlier attempts to find the exit. The corridor lights flickered harder in response, and for a second the conveyor belt beneath her feet jerked, as if it had noticed her listening.

Mara looked down at the belt. The metal grating moved in pulses, not continuous. It surged forward, then paused, then surged again, like a playback head skipping. When it paused, her shoe stuck to it for half a breath before the belt pulled free. The sensation was intimate and nauseating - like the tape was holding her in place just long enough to make her feel trapped.

She had wanted a stable escape path. Something that didn't keep rearranging itself. But the transition itself - playground to factory - felt intentional. Recurring. Stitch's presence wasn't just in the laughter. It was in the way the environment obeyed his timing, flipping her from one set to another when she got too close to the wrong kind of certainty.

Mara forced her feet to step with the belt's pulse instead of fighting it. She waited for the belt to surge, then moved in step, letting the motion carry her forward for a few steps. The corridor's walls glistened with condensation. Her jeans stuck to her legs where sweat met cold air. Somewhere behind her, the static hissed louder, like the tape was rewinding.

She reached out toward the floating slice of doorway light. It was still there, still pulsing, still just out of reach. The distance felt smaller than before, but the corridor tightened visually - perspective warping, walls seeming to lean in. The closer she got, the less space she had to misstep.

Stitch's laughter surged again, and this time it wasn't behind her. It came from somewhere ahead, higher than her head, like it was coming from the ceiling lights themselves. The audio layer shifted - laughter over conveyor over static over a half-remembered melody - until Mara couldn't tell which sound marked the next transition.

Her fear tried to make her freeze.

Then she heard something else: a faint dragging noise beneath the corridor's rhythm, a scrape that didn't belong to machinery. Like claws along metal, slow and patient. Mara jerked her head around, scanning the dark between the blinking lamps.

Nothing moved in the shadows. But the scrape returned, closer, and the laughter cut into a grin-sounding rhythm that made her teeth hurt.

Mara didn't have time to interpret it. She had to choose.

She stepped forward hard, aiming not for the floating doorway light, but for the narrow gap between two conveyor sections where the belt's grating changed design.

The corridor narrowed there, a tight seam in the machinery that looked like it might open if the tape wanted it to. It wasn't a door, not exactly. It was a possibility.

Her foot landed on the seam and the belt shuddered under her weight. A vibration ran up her leg, and the lights ahead flashed so bright her eyes watered. In that flash, the corridor's walls rippled like film. For half a heartbeat, Mara saw the carousel again layered over the factory - wooden horses ghosted across metal panels, hollow eyes staring through the wrong surface.

The tape was stacking images, forcing choices into contradictions.

Mara lunged through the seam as the lights died.

Cold darkness swallowed her, thick and wet, and the conveyor's grind cut off like a cord pulled from a machine. Her body fell - too far for a corridor, too fast for a door - and she hit something springy and wrong, a bounce that suggested she'd landed on another edited set entirely.

Stitch's laughter landed with her.

Not just sound this time. It resonated through the surface beneath her palms, vibrating her bones like a bass note. She pushed herself upright, tasting static in the back of her throat. The world steadied for a moment: carousel ring beneath her hands, but the factory smell still clung to the air. Two realities overlapped and refused to choose.

Then the overlap snapped.

The carousel vanished again, replaced by a tighter factory corridor, narrower than before, the conveyor lights blinking faster - too fast for her breathing to keep up. Mara scrambled forward, one hand scraping sparks from the metal edge, and the corridor tightened around her in the same way the tape had tightened the doorway slice earlier.

She'd slipped past the carousel.

And the tape had taken the win and made it smaller.

Mara's mouth went dry. Her fingers tightened around the edge of the belt as if she could hold the scene in place by force. Stitch's laughter echoed ahead, now louder, and behind it the dragging scrape returned, closer, syncing with the conveyor's pulse like something had found her position on the timeline.

The escape path wasn't broad anymore. It was a corridor with no room for hesitation, no room for misreading.

Only forward, only glitch-light, only the sound of Stitch keeping time.

CHAPTER 3

Hallway Claws and the Red-Tinted Flash

The corridor didn't widen when Mara ran. It only breathed - steel-gray walls flexing in the corner of her vision, the factory smell of warm dust and old grease pooling in her throat like she'd swallowed a penny. Ahead, the far end held a single flickering light, a stuttering eye that turned on, turned off, then on again like it couldn't remember what it was supposed to show.

Behind her, somewhere in the dark, Stitch's laughter kept time. It wasn't loud enough to locate, not really. It came in the gaps between the light's pulses, slipping under her skin and making her footsteps sound wrong. The sound of claws against metal scraped once - close, then not close at all - followed by the soft, rubbery thump of something shifting its weight.

Mara angled her body toward the brightest moment of the flicker and forced herself to move with it. If she could time her steps to the light, she could keep the distance from warping. She'd learned that much in the playground: when the image stuttered, the world stuttered with it, and she could steal a half-second before the tape decided to correct her.

She reached out, fingers grazing the wall. The surface felt like painted drywall stretched too tight, then like wet paper, then like something that had once been skin. Her hand came away with a faint tackiness that smelled faintly of burnt sugar and old VHS plastic. She didn't look at it. She couldn't afford to.

The corridor narrowed again as if it resented her confidence. The light ahead blinked faster, the rhythm breaking into jittery bursts. Mara's stomach tightened. She tried to keep her eyes on the far end, but the shadows on the walls started misbehaving -

elongating, snapping back, then stretching sideways as though the corridor had turned without her.

Stitch's shadow darted across the near wall, a black cutout with too many joints. It moved with intention, not just motion, and Mara's eyes tracked it the way a drowning person tracks a shoreline. When the silhouette swept left, she stepped left. When it snapped right, she corrected. The air grew colder near the wall, warmer near the floor, like the corridor was running two different temperatures and refusing to pick one.

A flash stung her peripheral vision - white-blue, too fast to process. Something like a mascot grin appeared on the far wall for a blink, then smeared into static. Mara flinched anyway, because her mind insisted she'd seen it clearly: bright eyes, cracked and over-rendered, a face that didn't belong in this hallway.

"Stitch," she whispered, the word scraping out of her like a cough. She wanted to anchor herself to the only familiar moving piece, even if familiar meant cursed.

Her own voice sounded thick in the dark, swallowed by the corridor's metallic hush. Stitch's laughter answered, closer now, then farther, like the tape was moving it through channels.

Mara tightened her grip on her bag strap until her knuckles hurt. She didn't know what she was carrying - she only knew she'd lost track of what was real when the playground carousel animals started missing their heads and still somehow kept turning. The hallway light pulsed. Each pulse seemed to drag the shadows with it, stretching them toward her and then snapping them away before she could pin down the direction of danger.

She reached the point where the corridor's wall seam met a dent. Her shoulder brushed it and the dent gave, not like a dent but like a mouth pressing its tongue against her. The smell thickened - hot plastic, sour milk, and something faintly electrical.

Another flash cut across the wall - this time faster, more aggressive. A red-tinted smear of a cartoon grin, teeth too many and too sharp, eyes that jittered between

animated and lifelike. Sonic. Tails. The names didn't come from any voice; they came from Mara's brain trying to categorize the distortion into something it recognized. The flashes screamed without sound - her ears ringing anyway, as if the image itself had weight.

Mara stumbled a half-step, then caught herself before she hit the wall. The corridor light stuttered, and for that split second she thought she could see a figure at the far end - something pale and rounded behind the flicker - then the image broke and the far end became only distance again.

She sucked in a breath that tasted like dust and old static.

Stitch's shadow slid across the wall toward her left foot. Mara followed it without thinking, because thinking had started to lag behind the tape. She pivoted and ran two steps, counting the flickers in her head. One - dark. Two - light. Three - dark. On the fourth, she meant to surge forward, commit to the brightest moment and carry her body through it before the corridor could correct her position.

The corridor refused.

The light flared, but it didn't flare true. It bloomed red for an instant, as if the bulb had turned inside out, and the shadows scrambled like insects under glass. Mara's sense of left and right turned unreliable. The wall she'd been touching felt suddenly behind her shoulder, and the floor beneath her feet felt like it had shifted forward by a few inches.

She tried to grab the wall to steady herself and instead her fingers met air. The corridor's cold returned in a quick wave, raising gooseflesh along her arms. The sound of claws scraping metal came again - closer than it had any right to be - then cut off so abruptly it left a ringing silence.

Mara's mind jumped to the place where Stitch would be if her eyes were right. She threw her gaze to the shadow, hunting for the shape she'd been using as a compass.

Stitch's silhouette wasn't on the wall anymore.

It was on the floor.

Or maybe the floor had become a wall. The shadow pooled like ink, then snapped upward, stretching into a long, wrong angle that pointed straight at her chest. Mara froze for a breath, because freezing was the only way she could prevent herself from running into whatever the tape wanted her to collide with.

The hallway light flickered hard - three rapid blinks - then steadied for one terrifying moment. In that steadiness, Mara saw the end of the corridor clearly: a doorway of sorts, a rectangle of darker darkness, rimmed with the faintest red tint like dried blood under glass.

Hope flared so fast it hurt.

She moved. Not running - sliding forward with her palms out, ready to catch herself if the floor betrayed her again. Her shoes scraped over grit. The smell of warm dust sharpened into something sharper, like overheated circuitry.

"Stitch," she said again, louder this time, because she needed the tape to hear her, to remember the rules it had been pretending to follow.

The laughter came immediately after, but it didn't match her pace. Stitch's amusement arrived like a delay, like the sound was chasing her from somewhere behind the screen. Then - another flash, bigger, meaner.

Mascots smeared across the walls in rapid succession, red-tinted and grotesque. Sonic's grin, cracked and overlaid with static. Tails' eyes jittering like they were being dragged through an analog filter that couldn't decide whether it wanted to be cute or cruel. Their shapes weren't stable enough to be fully seen, but their presence was unmistakable in the way they made Mara's stomach drop.

The corridor light stuttered in sync with the flashes, pulling her momentum apart. Each time she tried to step through the darkness ahead, the image stung her eyes and the distance between her and the doorway doubled, then halved, then doubled again. Her body felt like it was moving through water that kept changing viscosity.

Mara clenched her jaw until it ached. She forced her eyes shut for one blink, counted the hum of the VHS static she'd been hearing since the living room, and opened them on the next flicker.

The doorway was closer.

Not by much. Close enough to make her believe, close enough to cost her caution. She reached forward with her left hand and felt the edge of something solid - cool, smooth, slightly tacky. The doorway wasn't a doorway in the normal sense. It was a boundary drawn in light and glare, like the tape had decided where reality should stop and printed the rest in darkness.

Her fingertips brushed the rim, and the corridor shuddered. The wall seam she'd touched earlier reappeared beside her hand, as if the tape had rewound and slid the corridor over itself.

A voice - warped, childlike, wrong - leaked into the hallway from somewhere that wasn't audible and still somehow was. It wasn't a word so much as a melody that had been chewed into static. Aloha ¶Oe, stretched and mutilated by the tape's hiss, the tune rising and falling like breath through a torn speaker.

Mara's throat tightened. She'd heard warped song before, back when Stitch stood alone in that dark empty room and the screen had flashed a glimpse of something dangling just out of frame. The tape remembered. The tape always remembered.

Stitch's shadow cut across her face, and she felt heat on her cheeks like a flashbulb going off inches from her skin.

She pulled her hand back and lunged forward anyway, committing to the doorway while the light was on. Her shoulder slammed into the boundary with a wet, papery resistance, and her body jerked as if something inside the tape had grabbed her from the other side.

Then - release.

For a breath, Mara was beyond the corridor's rules. The air around her felt less metallic. The smell of dust softened into something cooler, almost clean. The flickering light was behind her now, and for one glorious, nauseating second she thought she'd made it.

The relief lasted exactly as long as the tape allowed.

The screen - or the world, or whatever this hallway was pretending to be - went wrong again. The light ahead flashed red, and with it came the mascot scream, rapid-fire and identity-distorting, Sonic and Tails appearing as grotesque, detailed shapes for a handful of frames. Their faces didn't just flicker; they latched onto the hallway itself, overlaying distance with a grin that didn't belong to any cartoon.

Mara's eyes watered from the strain. The corridor's geometry collapsed into jitter. The doorway rim under her hand blurred into static texture, tiny black specks crawling over her skin as if the boundary was trying to become screen grain.

Stitch's laughter spiked, sharper now, like it had learned to cut.

Mara tried to turn her head, tried to find Stitch's shadow again, tried to anchor herself to the only moving compass she had left. But the shadows were everywhere and nowhere, smeared across walls that no longer agreed on where they stood. Her sense of direction buckled. Left became forward. Forward became back. The hallway light stuttered so violently her eyes couldn't keep up.

She reached for the doorway edge one more time, fingers searching for that cool, tacky rim.

Her fingertips met only static.

The corridor vanished in a snap of red-tinted glitching. Sonic and Tails flashed one last time - grotesque and cracked and too real for the second they appeared - then the world dissolved into grainy darkness that sounded like wet paper tearing. Mara's breath caught on the hiss, and the sound of claws dragging against metal echoed through the static like a countdown she couldn't stop.

The last thing she saw was a smear of Stitch's grin in the red flare - too wide, too bright - before the picture cut hard to nothing but noise.

CHAPTER 4

Clock Digits Scratched Into a Tail

The red smear of Stitch's grin still burned at the edge of her vision when the world snapped to hiss. Mara's palms hit something cold and papery - static that felt like wet dust sliding under her nails - and the air tasted like overheated plastic. The factory corridor was gone. The claws-on-metal sound cut out mid-scratch, replaced by a thin, patient tone that seemed to come from inside her teeth.

She blinked hard and the room didn't come back. It only reassembled itself around a new shape: a clock-side mechanism, all angles and moving parts that didn't belong in any living room. Gears hung in the air like suspended ribs. Thin brass ribs arced into a frame, and there - where a normal clock face should have been - there was only a circle with no numbers. A pale disk, scratched blank. Each scratch caught the dim light and looked like someone had tried to write time and failed.

Stitch was there, too. Not in front of her like a person - closer to how a stain is present in a wall. His outline kept flickering behind the moving parts, as if the clock itself was remembering him wrong. Somewhere near the center, dark fluid dripped from a tail that never appeared cleanly. It slid in slow, deliberate drops, each one making the brass smell sharper, metallic and sour, like pennies held under the tongue.

Mara swallowed. The static tone rose, then steadied, as if the tape had decided on a frequency and wanted her to match it.

"Okay," she rasped, not sure if her voice carried or if it just smeared against the hiss. "Clock. Fine."

She didn't have to be told what she wanted; her body already knew. She needed orientation. If the tape was going to keep relocating her through glitches, then the clock's structure had to mean something - some repeatable logic, some direction she could trust. The circle with no digits felt like a locked door with the handle missing. But scratched marks were still marks. Someone had touched this dial. Someone - or something - had been trying to leave instructions.

Mara stepped closer, forcing her eyes to stay on the disk instead of the tail dripping beside it. Each droplet hit the mechanism with a soft, wrong sound, like ink landing on cloth. She leaned in until her breath fogged the air in front of the scratched circle. The scratches weren't random. They clustered in groups, like clock digits had once been there and been scraped away in a hurry.

A smear of Stitch's silhouette shifted between gears. The hiss deepened, turning thick. The moving parts ticked without hands, clicking like teeth.

Mara traced the edge of the circle with her fingertip. The brass was cold enough to hurt. Her finger came away with a faint residue - black, tacky, like old marker - and for a second the disk looked... different. Not numbers exactly, but the ghost of them. The scratches seemed to align, to suggest shapes that could be read if she wanted them hard enough.

She tried anyway. The topmost cluster - too shallow to be letters, too deliberate to be damage - hinted at something like a "2," or maybe a "7" if the angle was wrong. The next group down looked like a broken "4." The bottom scratches were a smear that could have been a "9" if the tape hadn't blurred the lines.

She straightened, heart thudding in her ribs with a rhythm that didn't match the clock's tick.

"Missing digits," she whispered. "Like... the tape took them."

The hiss answered her, not with words, but with a brief visual stutter - her own reflection warping in the brass, her face fractured into bands of red and gray. In one

band, Stitch's grin looked wider than it should. In another, her hand was in a different position, as if the clock had already tried to rearrange her.

Mara jerked her gaze back. The dial's scratches seemed to shift under her attention. When she looked directly, the shapes blurred again into meaningless scars. When she glanced away, they sharpened for the blink of a second - enough to be a clue and not enough to be sure.

That was the first obstacle: the tape wouldn't let her hold the answer. Every time she formed a pattern, it pulled her eyes off it, or warped the marks into something else. The clock ticked like impatience. Stitch's tail dripped darker, faster now, and the smell of it crawled up her nose.

Mara pressed her palm flat against the brass ring. "No," she said, louder this time, like she could command the VHS to behave. "You're not just damage. You're a message."

The hiss dropped in pitch. The mechanism's gears jerked, and for a moment the whole frame lurched - clock-side metal grinding as if it had been forced to remember a different function. A thin panel in the mechanism slid open with a sound like wet paper tearing, and inside, a narrow slot glimmered.

Not a button. Not a lever.

A strip of tape, curled and frayed at the edges, dangling like a tongue from a throat.

Mara reached for it before she could talk herself out of it. Her fingers closed on the tape and it was warm, warm like skin. The moment she touched it, the hiss spiked, and the dial's scratches flared as if ink had soaked into them overnight.

Shapes snapped into place - this time, unmistakable. A set of digits formed in the scratches, each one scratched deep enough to feel like a wound. Mara leaned in, reading them as they appeared, counting under her breath.

Then the numbers vanished.

Not gradually. Not with a fade.

They were cut out of the world like someone had edited them away. The disk returned to blank scars, and the warm strip of tape in her hand went limp, cold, and useless.

Mara stared at the empty scratch-circle, her mouth dry. Her hand still held black residue. The tape strip had left a smear on her skin, and when she rubbed it, the residue didn't come off. It sank in, as if her fingers were absorbing the same corrupted ink that dripped from Stitch.

"You're kidding," she said.

Stitch's laughter flickered through the hiss - small and distant, like it was happening behind a wall made of static. The tail's dripping slowed, then stopped. The absence felt deliberate. The mechanism's gears shifted again, and this time the clock's frame rotated, not toward a doorway, but toward a new section of the environment.

The brass ribs unfolded into something wider than a room. The air changed. It lost the plastic smell and gained dust - dry, stale dust, layered over something metallic and old. Her ears caught a faint, rhythmic clank.

Mara backed away from the dial, eyes scanning for a safe vantage point. She wasn't thinking about escape as a single solution anymore. The tape was making her chase answers while it moved the goalposts. But she could still use the movement. If the digits were a clue, then the clue wasn't the digits themselves - it was where they pointed.

"Okay," she said again, voice tight. "If you don't show me the numbers, you show me what they lead to."

The mechanism's rotating frame settled, and the blank dial faced forward like a signpost. The scratched circle wasn't readable now, but the arrangement of scratches - how they clustered, where the deepest scars were - had a pattern she couldn't unsee. She'd been trying to decode it like a clock face, but the tape had been treating it like coordinates.

Mara moved along the edge of the mechanism, following the direction the frame now opened toward. Her shoes scraped on something gritty. The temperature dropped a few degrees. The hiss was still there, but it had thinned into a background crawl, like a tape playing under a door.

She found the transition seam: a gap in the mechanism's base, where the brass ribs ended and the world beyond began. It wasn't a doorway - more like the tape's image had torn, and the tear was where she was being pulled through.

Beyond it lay a desolate field, gray under a sky that looked too flat to be real. Dead grass bent in unnatural directions. The air smelled of rust and wet stone, even though nothing was wet. And in the distance, framed by the skeletal remains of fences and broken posts, a rusted train sat on tracks that curved like a question mark.

The sound of clanking grew louder with each step she took, as if the train was waking up in increments.

Mara's throat tightened. "No. Not that."

She couldn't see Stitch clearly, but the sense of him pressed close, like the tape's presence had migrated into the field. The tail's black residue on her fingers tingled. The scratches on the dial felt far away now, but her mind kept trying to hold the missing digits as if they were still there.

She turned toward the mechanism's edge again, searching for confirmation. The dial was still blank. No numbers. No digits. But the scratches - those clustered marks - looked different in this new light, as if the field's gray was making the ink ghosts visible.

A faint alignment formed along the rim: a set of scratch-segments that matched the rhythm of the train's clank. Mara listened, counting the clanks without thinking. The sequence matched the way the digits had flashed and been cut away inside the brass panel.

It wasn't enough to be certain. But it was enough to make her move.

She crouched at the edge of the seam and peered into the field. The train's rusted body was pitted and scabbed, its windows dark like bruises. No smoke rose. No steam. It looked dead.

And yet the clank continued, steady as a heartbeat.

A voice - warped, thin - pushed through the background noise. Not Stitch's laugh this time. Something closer to a sing-song murmur, stretched by tape flutter until it sounded like a lullaby being played backward.

Mara stood, frozen for a breath. "Lilo's voice," she said, though she didn't know if she was right. The tape used echoes the way it used glitches: to trick the mind into filling in blanks.

From behind her, the mechanism behind the seam shuddered. The brass dial rotated slightly, and in that movement, the scratched marks seemed to rearrange. The cluster that had looked like a "2" now suggested a "5." The "4" became a smear that could have been a "1." Her interpretation shifted under her like sand.

The second obstacle hit hard: every clue she tried to lock onto kept changing depending on where she stood, what she looked at, what she expected to see. Inquiry became a trap. Each answer she formed contradicted itself the moment she tried to use it.

Mara's mouth went sour. The black residue on her fingers itched. She felt the tape's pressure, not in her ears but in her eyes - urging her to watch, to decode, to chase until she was too tired to resist.

She had a choice. Stay at the seam, keep trying to read the clock's scratches until the tape rewrote them again and again. Or commit to the only thing that had stayed consistent: the direction the mechanism pointed when it rotated toward the field.

Mara took one step toward the tracks.

The train responded instantly. The clanking shifted into a deeper grind, metal complaining as if it hadn't been used in years and was furious about it. The rusted wheels began to turn. No hands pulled a lever. No engine roared. It simply started moving - slow at first, then with stubborn certainty, like it had been waiting for her to step into its path.

Mara stumbled back, heel scraping on grit. The train didn't stop. It rolled forward with the same rhythm as the dial's scratched clusters, as if the numbers had been hidden inside the movement all along.

"Stitch," she said, not as a name but as a demand for the tape to stop lying. "If you want me - show me!"

Her voice hit the field and came back warped, chewed by static. The train's windows flickered with dark reflections. For a moment, Mara saw a smear of a grin across one window, too large, too bright, stitched into the glass like it belonged there.

The train gained speed.

Mara ran - toward the side of the tracks, toward whatever shadow might offer a foothold. The field offered none. The dead grass swallowed her footsteps with a dry hiss. She reached the nearest railcar, grabbing at a rusted step that should have crumbled.

It didn't crumble.

Her fingers found a grip that wasn't there a second ago. The metal was slick with that same black residue, and when she pulled herself up, it stuck to her skin like tar.

She hauled herself onto the edge of the car, breath tearing in her throat. The door at the front of the car was shut. No handle. No latch that made sense. The window beside it showed only her reflection - split into bands - her face pale, eyes wide, and behind her, Stitch's outline flickering in the glass like a bad frame that refused to be deleted.

Mara leaned toward the window, searching for an opening, for a way to climb down and get to safety while the train still had distance between her and the rest of the field.

The train accelerated again.

Her grip slipped. The step under her foot shifted with the vibration of the engine that wasn't there. The car jerked forward, dragging her with it. Mara's stomach dropped as the ground fell away, and she realized the cost of her choice a second too late.

She wasn't boarding a train that would carry her.

She was being forced onto it.

Inside the car, the air was colder than outside, thick with old metal and something sweet-sour that reminded her of tape glue. The floorboards shuddered under her boots. The clank of the wheels became louder, like a countdown she couldn't pause.

Mara scrambled deeper into the car, one hand clawing at a seam in the wall. The rusted metal was etched with scratches - lines that looked accidental until they caught the light. Then they formed clusters.

Digits.

Scratched into the train's body like someone had carved time into rust and called it a lock.

Mara stared at them, and the knowledge hit her with a sick clarity: the clock hadn't been for telling time. It had been for teaching the tape's logic - where to place her, when to move, how to turn orientation into captivity.

The train kept moving, pulling her forward with every clank.

Somewhere in the hiss, Stitch's laughter sounded closer now, not guiding - claiming the rhythm. Mara pressed her forehead against the rusted wall, tasting black residue

and stale air, and listened to the scratched digits answer the wheels as they carried her away from the field and deeper into whatever the tape had lined up next.

CHAPTER 5

Eyeball Crush and the Family-Word Rot

The train kept moving, pulling her forward with every clank.

Somewhere in the hiss, Stitch's laughter sounded closer now, not guiding - claiming the rhythm. Mara pressed her forehead against the rusted wall, tasting black residue and stale air, and listened to the scratched digits answer the wheels as they carried her away from the field and deeper into whatever the tape had decided was next.

Metal vibrated through her bones. The floor under her boots didn't feel like a floor anymore. It felt like a moving strip of something stitched together - boards that flexed wrong, seams that tugged at her ankles the way a frayed tape might catch a fingertip. She tried to look down, but the view smeared, as if the camera had blinked and forgotten how to render wood.

Then the world snapped.

Not a cut to static - worse. The train's motion kept going, but the ground beneath her became a wooden floor again, pale slats running in tight lines like the ribs of a cheap dollhouse. The air turned warmer, varnish-sweet and rotten at the edges. The sound of wheels became a distant throat-clear, stretched and thin, like the tape was choking on its own signal.

Mara's stomach dropped anyway.

Above her, the ceiling of the distorted living room pressed low, beams warped as if someone had melted the straight lines and forced them back into place. Somewhere, faint and childish, a warped Aloha ʻŌe bled through the audio track - notes too slow,

too bent - like a lullaby played on a tape that had been left in a hot car until it forgot how to be music.

Stitch didn't need to appear. The laughter was enough - soft clicks in the back of her skull, timing her fear.

She forced her eyes to the floorboards. If the tape wanted her to watch, she would watch back. Her goal wasn't comfort or escape anymore; it was pattern. The stitched imagery - the digits, the pauses, the way the corridor had narrowed right after a red flash - had a rhythm. Mara needed to catch it before it caught her.

The wooden slats ahead of her began to shimmer, and in that shimmer she saw it: a sequence of dark knots in the grain, spaced like numbers. Not random. Not furniture scarring. They aligned with the memory of the scratched dial from the last place - missing pieces, gaps filled by the tape's own insistence.

She crouched, fingers hovering over a knot that looked like a dot. The wood was warm. Too warm. Like it had been pressed against skin.

From somewhere behind her, the laughter sharpened. "Heh - ha - heh - "

Mara stood too fast. Her heel slipped on a seam that hadn't been there a breath ago. She grabbed the edge of a warped chair leg - its surface slick with residue that smelled like pennies and old milk - and jerked herself upright.

"Don't," she rasped, though the room didn't answer.

The floor responded anyway.

The seam opened like a mouth.

It didn't split smoothly; it crushed. One board bowed under her weight, then another, and another, until the slats formed a tight grid that began to squeeze upward. Mara tried to jump back, but the train's momentum was still inside her - still pushing her forward like a hand on her spine. Her boots slid. The wood tightened.

And then something wet flashed through the crack.

A single eyeball - wrongly large, too glossy - popped into view as if the floor had swallowed it whole and decided to show her the proof. It rolled once. The iris contracted. A thin film dragged behind it like a thread.

The sound that came next wasn't a scream. It was a crunch that sounded like someone snapping ice under a boot, followed by a wet, papery hiss as the eyeball was pressed flat against the underside of the floor.

Mara staggered, hands clawing at the air. The smell hit her hard: blood-sweet and metallic, mixed with varnish. Her throat tightened with a reflexy gag that wouldn't commit to vomiting - just held on, refusing to let her breathe right.

The laughter cut out.

Static surged in its place, not the usual hiss but a dark wet hush, like water filling a throat. In the warped audio, the Aloha ʻŌe broke apart into syllables that didn't belong in a song. Words surfaced through the distortion, thick as grease.

"Ohana," it said.

Mara froze. The word had always sounded like safety in stories. Even when the tape was wrong, it had carried that comfort before - like a lure. She'd been trying to read patterns, trying to predict Stitch's next move, and now the tape offered her a phrase that should've meant family.

Only it came out cracked and poisoned, stretched until the vowels sounded like something being pulled through teeth.

" - means," the audio stuttered, then corrected itself with a hissed emphasis, as if the cassette head had scratched the sentence into new meaning.

"Ohana means - family."

The lights in the room flickered in time with the phrase. The wooden floor's grid tightened again, and this time the seams didn't just open - they crawled. Dark shapes slid between boards, pushing up like bruises.

Mara backed away, but the floor followed her in that same cruel way the corridor had followed her - only here the pursuit wasn't about distance. It was about alignment. The boards seemed to want her feet exactly where they had been when the eyeball crushed.

She looked down again, breath shallow, and found herself staring at the knots in the wood. The sequence she'd tried to read was still there, but now it looked like a targeting reticle. The knots weren't numbers. They were punctuation. The tape was using texture like language.

When she shifted her weight to test a different board, the floor answered with another pop of wet shine - another eyeball, smaller, then smaller still, as if the tape was escalating. Each one appeared for a fraction, each one crushed, each one accompanied by a sound like a camera lens being smashed.

Her hands went numb from gripping the chair leg so hard her knuckles hurt.

"Stitch!" she shouted, and the room swallowed the word. Her voice sounded thin, stretched by the VHS distortion. "What are you doing?"

The laughter returned, not behind her this time but inside the static, braided through it. It didn't feel playful. It felt like a metronome set to torture.

The warped audio leaned into the phrase again, louder, clearer, as if the tape had decided she needed the trigger more than the warning.

"Ohana - means - family."

The floor stopped moving for one blink. Mara's eyes widened. For a moment she thought she'd found it - the pattern, the key. Maybe the sequence would change if she

responded correctly. Maybe if she treated the phrase like a code instead of a comfort, she could steer the tape.

Then the chair leg under her hand twitched.

The wood - stitching itself, warping - pulled her wrist forward. The residue on the chair felt tacky, and her skin dragged across it with a sound like tape being peeled from plastic. Mara yrenched back, but the chair didn't let go. It held her as if her grip had become part of the mechanism.

In the crack between boards, a shadow moved - not an eyeball now, but a bulge like something heavy pressing up from below. The seam tightened around it, and the pressure made the room's sound distort. Mara's ears popped. The edges of her vision went grainy.

The phrase hit again, this time with an extra bite to the "family," like it was the knife.

"Ohana means family."

Mara's mind tried to grab the wrong meaning and got snagged. Comfort didn't belong here. The tape wasn't offering her a hug. It was trying to cue her into a reflex - into an obedience.

She let go of the chair leg.

The moment her hand left the residue, the floor's grip slackened, as if the mechanism had been waiting for her to make the choice the tape wanted. The seam snapped shut with a wet click. The room's warmth drained fast, replaced by a cold damp that crept up her shins.

Mara stumbled backward, breath shaking. She didn't understand everything, but she understood enough to act. If "family" was a trigger, then she wouldn't feed it her instinct. She wouldn't answer the phrase like it was safe.

She forced her eyes away from the floor and toward anything that looked like an exit: a doorway, a wall gap, a change in the warped living room's geometry.

The room didn't offer one.

Instead, the image slid sideways.

The wooden slats blurred into something darker, then into something that wasn't wood at all. The living room beams dissolved into fog-thick air. The air smelled of wet leaves and rot. Her skin prickled with cold as if she'd stepped into shade under a tree that had never seen daylight.

Mara's boots found ground again, but not boards. Loose dirt sucked at her soles. The sound of the train faded into a distant hiss, replaced by a thin, constant moan like wind through a throat.

She spun.

Fog swallowed the edges of the world. Trees stood as pale shapes in it, their trunks too long, their branches too sparse - like a sketch that had been stretched beyond comfort. The mist clung to her eyelashes. When she blinked, it left tiny cold streaks on her cheeks.

Somewhere close, a voice sang - warped, breathy, not quite human. The Aloha ☐Oe fragment returned, but it didn't soothe. It crawled through the fog like a signal searching for a receiver.

And then the silhouette appeared.

Sirens didn't have bodies, but the tape had decided to draw one anyway. A tall, skeletal spine of something stood between trees, head like a stretched funnel, too smooth and too wrong. Siren Head's shape was all angles and distance, its presence made of silhouette and sound. It didn't roar. It simply listened, and the listening itself made Mara's teeth ache.

A second shape moved farther back - longer than the trees, lower to the ground, too careful. Long Horse, its body a long smear of shadow and muscle, hooves barely

touching the dirt. Its movement wasn't a walk. It was a correction, like the world was being re-aligned around it.

Mara backed up until her shoulder hit a trunk. The bark was slick and cold, and when she pressed her palm to it, the texture flickered - like the tree was being rendered late.

"No," she whispered, and the fog swallowed the word too fast.

Stitch's laughter came again, distant now, threaded through the moaning wind. It wasn't guiding her. It was counting down.

The warped audio surged one last time, and the phrase returned like a warning label burned into her nerves.

"Ohana means family."

Mara's stomach turned. She realized with a sick clarity that the tape wasn't just repeating the words. It was using them to reframe what "family" meant inside the distortion - something that could crush you, something that could pull you into its shape.

Long Horse shifted.

Its head angled upward, and the air around Mara tightened, like pressure building in a tube. The dirt under her feet loosened. Her balance tipped. She grabbed at the tree, but the bark felt too slick, like it wanted her hand to slip.

Sirens Head's presence made the fog vibrate. A low hum rolled through the mist, and her ears filled with static that tasted like pennies.

Mara tried to run - tried to choose a direction and commit to it - but the fog thickened in response, making her choices feel swallowed. Her steps sank and then lurched, as if the ground beneath her was changing under the soles of her boots.

A snap of motion cut through the wind.

Long Horse's entire body jerked upward, not toward her like an attack, but like a machine being yanked by a cable. The ground popped as if something underneath had been pulled taut. Mara's feet lifted an inch - then a foot - then she was off the dirt completely.

Her arms flailed. Her fingers brushed fog that felt heavy, like wet cloth. The cold air wrapped around her ribs. The world tilted, trees stretching into vertical lines that smeared into grain.

She saw the wooden floor flash behind her for one terrible blink - boards and seams and the crushed eyeball shine - like the tape was dragging the last image forward to remind her what the phrase had meant.

Then it was gone.

Mara hung in open air, suspended just long enough to understand the cost of her decision. She hadn't been able to read Stitch's next move in time. She'd survived the floor, but the tape had already rewritten the rules again. Now there was no ground route to take, no pattern she could follow with her feet.

Sirens Head stood in the fog, a listening silhouette, and Long Horse snapped higher, lifting her farther away from any tree she could grab.

Stitch's laughter ticked through the static like a clock that didn't care about her timing.

Mara's boots kicked uselessly at empty air as the fog swallowed the forest around her and split her from the only thing she could've used - solid ground.

CHAPTER 6

Staircase Bottom and the 180-Degree Turn

Long Horse's hide was cold through Mara's palms, like damp felt left out in the fog, and the spiral of the world kept pulling at her balance even when she stood still. Somewhere above, the staircase kept turning - endless steps with no top, no bottom, just the same rhythm of tread and drop repeating like a tape that refused to finish. The fog had thinned into something stranger near her feet, a grainy gray that looked more like static than mist. It caught in her eyelashes. It made the sound of Stitch's laughter feel close enough to bite.

Mara tried to keep her eyes on the direction Stitch's shadow used to point her, but the fog ate edges first. Long Horse's head dipped as if listening, and its breath steamed faintly, not warm - just present, just proof that something solid still existed. "Hold," Mara whispered, and didn't know if she was telling Long Horse or herself.

The staircase answered by tightening.

The steps under Long Horse's hooves didn't so much move as rewrite themselves. One moment the railing was there, a twisted line of darkness she could reach for; the next, it was gone, replaced by a vertical wall of slick, stitched seams. The fog thickened, then broke apart in patches, like the picture on a failing VHS. In those patches, Mara saw the living room again for a blink - twisted furniture legs melting into the floor, the wrong angle of a window that shouldn't have existed - then the image snapped back into the turning staircase.

Mara's stomach lurched. She clutched Long Horse tighter, knuckles whitening until the cold in its fur felt like needles.

She wanted a bottom. Not an answer, not a way out - just an end. If there was a place where the tape couldn't keep looping, she could plant her feet there, force her mind to stop flinching every time the screen stuttered. She'd been running on scraps of route all day: one shadow, one flicker, one sound that meant something. But the fog had split her from solid ground, and now the staircase was doing what the tape did best - taking away the idea that she could control anything.

Long Horse shifted, hooves scraping on a step that didn't want to stay a step. Mara felt it through her hands, the surface turning slick and then rough again, as if the world couldn't decide what texture it was supposed to be.

"Stitch," she said, and the name came out wrong in the static-thick air, stretched and warped like audio played at the wrong speed. Her voice sounded too thin. Too far away from her own mouth.

Long Horse didn't answer. But the laughter did.

It rolled through the staircase like a recording with a loose tape inside the VCR - sometimes ahead, sometimes behind, never landing where it should. Mara tried to follow it anyway. She shifted her weight, letting Long Horse guide her toward the only thing that felt consistent: the staircase's relentless turn, the way it kept presenting her with a curve like an arm reaching around her.

Then the steps stopped pretending.

A single landing appeared beneath Long Horse with no warning, as if the tape had decided it had finally reached a cut point. The air dropped colder. The fog fell away from Mara's face like a curtain being yanked. She tasted something metallic on her tongue, the kind of taste that comes when you press your mouth too close to an old TV speaker.

The landing wasn't a landing. It was a threshold.

A doorway stood at the bottom of the spiral staircase, but it wasn't attached to anything solid. It looked like a rectangle cut into darkness, edges flickering as if the

picture couldn't hold. Beyond it: black, thick and wet-looking. Not the fog-black she'd been walking through - this was the absence of image, a screen held fully off.

Mara's heart stuttered. She wanted to step through. She also wanted to slam the door shut on the idea that this was the end of her momentum. Her fingers tightened on Long Horse's fur until it hurt, and the hurt made her feel real, made her feel like there was still a choice inside her.

She took one step toward the doorway.

The landing lurched under her, and for a second she thought she'd misjudged the bottom, that she'd fall again into another endless turn. Long Horse braced, hooves scraping, and Mara forced herself to stop moving. Her mind snapped to a single thought, sharp as broken glass: if she kept walking, the tape would keep rewriting her.

So she waited.

In the silence between the staircase's distant creak and Stitch's laughter, Mara heard another sound - thin, grainy static, like a throat clearing. It came from the doorway itself. Not from the air. From inside the black.

She tried to steady her breathing, but her lungs didn't cooperate. The static made her chest feel tight, like the sound had weight.

"Okay," she said, and the word didn't feel like permission. It felt like a dare.

Long Horse's head angled toward the doorway. Its eyes were dark mirrors that didn't show reflections - just slight movement, like the surface of water trembling. Mara leaned forward, peering into the rectangle of black.

A flicker cut through it, VHS-style, a brief smear of image that couldn't decide what it was showing. The grain thickened. Lines of distortion crawled across the darkness like ants.

Then the black opened wider.

Not into a room. Into a screen.

Mara flinched back, but the doorway didn't move. The darkness stayed pinned in place, and within it a TV appeared - an old boxy set, screen turned toward her. The static on it wasn't random. It had rhythm, a constant hiss that sounded impatient, like someone tapping a fingernail on glass.

Mara's throat went dry. She pressed her palm against the doorway edge without thinking, expecting cold air or some barrier. Her hand met something warm instead - tacky, residue-thick, like she'd smeared her fingers on old tape. The smell hit her a moment later: scorched plastic and something faintly sweet, like overheated electronics.

The tape strip.

Even without seeing it, she felt the memory of it, frayed and dangling from the clock mechanism in the last loop of reality. Warm to the touch. Carrying residue. Stitch always seemed to leave pieces behind, as if he needed proof that the world could be stitched back together with the same wrong thread.

Mara pulled her hand away and stared at her fingers. They were smeared with darkness that didn't behave like dirt. It shimmered when she moved, catching the light like ink under a projector.

"Stitch," she said again, but her voice shook. "Show me."

The TV's static thickened in response, and for a blink Mara saw Stitch alone - standing in a dark empty room, his cartoon shape too sharp and too detailed at the same time. His eyes were wrong, snapping between lifelike and animated. He grinned as if he'd heard her, as if the request was a button.

Then the picture cut.

The doorway's black became a pitch-black room with walls that swallowed light. The TV sat inside it, centered like an altar, screen filling most of her vision. Mara could

hear the room without seeing it: the faint crackle of static, the heavy hum of electricity, and - underneath - footsteps that weren't hers, paced evenly like someone circling a chair.

Long Horse's fur trembled against her hands. Mara looked back toward the staircase and felt her stomach drop all over again.

The spiral was gone.

Not faded. Not obscured. Gone like the tape had snipped the world and removed the end of the picture. The doorway behind her was still there, still black and flickering, but it no longer connected to stairs. It was just a rectangle now, a dead exit that led nowhere she could stand.

Mara swallowed hard. "No," she whispered, because it was the only word that fit the shape of the panic in her throat.

The TV static surged. A low laugh threaded through it, Stitch's laughter layered under the hiss, like it had been recorded twice and offset by a second.

Mara backed away from the TV, but the floor didn't feel solid under her foot. It gave the slightest, like the room was a moving picture and she'd stepped on the frame. She reached for Long Horse without meaning to, and her hand found only air.

Long Horse was still close - she could feel it, the cold weight of its presence - but when she turned her head, she couldn't find it in the darkness. The room swallowed silhouettes. Her mind scrambled for it anyway, grabbing onto the idea of a steady anchor, and in that scramble she realized something worse than losing a route.

She didn't know what was real anymore.

Her objective had been simple in her head: hold steady at the endpoint long enough to find a stable exit cue. Now she was at an endpoint that erased the staircase, and the only cue in front of her was a TV that insisted on showing her the tape instead of letting her move.

Mara's hands curled into fists. She wanted to run, but there was nowhere to run. She wanted to hide, but the room offered no corners, no shadow that felt safe. Even the darkness felt like it was watching back.

The TV flickered.

In the static, two shapes coalesced, cartoonish and wrong in the way the earlier red-tinted glitches had been wrong - too crisp, too detailed, like the pixels were alive. A Cartoon Cat leaned into frame, its grin wide and stretched. A Cartoon Dog sat beside it, eyes bright with an expression that didn't match the soundless stillness.

They didn't speak. They didn't need to.

The static warped into laughter that wasn't Stitch's, a skittering giggle that sounded like torn tape being replayed over and over. Mara's skin prickled. The room's hum deepened until she could feel it in her teeth.

"Stop," she tried to say, but her voice died halfway. The TV answered by showing her something else - another flicker, a near-image of Stitch's dark empty room, his grin widening too fast, his head turning as if he'd heard a sound behind Mara's shoulder.

Mara spun.

There was nothing there. No footsteps. No Long Horse. Just the black walls and the TV's light pulsing in the center of everything she couldn't escape.

The TV's screen went momentarily clear, a harsh, grainy frame of Stitch standing alone, staring directly at the camera like he'd been waiting for a particular kind of panic. His mouth opened, but the audio that came out wasn't words. It was static shaped like a sentence, a hiss that formed the outline of something she'd heard before in warped songs and broken phrases.

Then Stitch's face snapped away from the camera and turned toward the side of the screen - as if he was looking at someone in the room with him.

Mara felt the hair on her arms rise.

The TV's image cut again, replaced by the Cartoon Cat and Cartoon Dog, both leaning forward now, their bodies tilting with a motion that didn't belong in animation. Their eyes tracked across the screen like they were searching for her in the dark.

Mara's panic made her stop thinking in solutions. It made her decide based on fear alone.

She grabbed the edge of the TV table - if it was a table. Her fingers met wood that felt too smooth, too new, and the surface vibrated under her grip like it had a heartbeat. The static hiss sharpened, and the room seemed to tighten around her hands.

"Stitch!" she barked, the name tearing out of her throat. "If you're - if you're there - "

The TV cut to black before she could finish. For a breath, the room was only hum and silence and her own frantic breathing.

Then the static returned, louder, wetter, the hiss thickening into something like paper being ripped underwater. The screen filled with rapid frames - glitches of the living room, the playground carousel, the factory corridor - each one slipping by too quickly to grab, like the tape couldn't decide which memory to use as a hook.

In one frame, Mara saw the staircase again. She saw the landing. She saw the doorway. She saw herself standing there, reaching out.

Her own arm in the image moved before Mara moved in the room. The tape version of her leaned forward as if invited.

Mara flinched, and the real room reacted a beat later, as though the tape was delayed and catching up.

The Cartoon Cat and Cartoon Dog appeared again, closer now, their faces filling the screen. Their expressions didn't change, but the static around them shifted, pulling their shapes into a deeper, more threatening focus. The hum of the room rose until it became almost a note.

Mara felt helpless witnessing her own motion being edited.

She tried to yank her hands away from the TV table, but her grip didn't loosen. Her fingers felt stuck to the surface with the same residue-thickness as the doorway edge. Panic flooded her again, hot and wrong.

She yanked harder.

The TV's screen brightened in response, and in the glare she saw Stitch's shadow flicker across the inside of the room - long and distorted, not attached to any body she could see. It moved like a hand searching for purchase.

Then Stitch's laughter cut through the hum like a blade.

Mara's arms went rigid. Her body fought her. Her mind screamed to run, to hide, to do anything that wasn't just being held in place by the tape's will.

She managed one small movement - enough to tilt her head toward the TV.

The screen showed static for half a second, then a clear frame: Stitch, grin stretched, eyes flickering between animated and lifelike. He turned his head, slow and deliberate, as if watching her struggle from somewhere just off-camera.

And the moment she saw him do it, the TV cut.

The black room vanished.

Mara fell sideways into a different kind of darkness, her feet slipping on something that wasn't a floor so much as a moving surface pretending to be one. The static hiss dropped out like a recording being muted. Her breath caught on the sudden absence.

She was still standing, somehow. Or standing enough.

Her face was close to a screen again, but this time the TV light cast thin gray edges over the room. The Cartoon Cat and Cartoon Dog were there in full, their cartoon

bodies seated like they owned the space. They stared at the TV, not at Mara - like the tape had decided she was the background now.

Mara's fingers finally loosened from the residue on the table. She pulled her hands back and watched the darkness smear across her palms like ink that refused to dry.

Behind the TV, somewhere too far to reach, Stitch's laughter continued - faint, patient - no longer guiding, no longer warning. Just existing, as if the tape had moved on to the next part of its endless loop.

Mara opened her mouth to call out, to demand the stairs back, to claw for a route with her voice.

But the TV static surged again, and the screen filled with flickering images of Stitch turning his head, over and over, like a cue waiting to be obeyed.

In the pitch-black silence between glitches, Mara realized the staircase had not just disappeared.

It had been replaced.



Reflection Eyes and the Crawling Lens

The dark room didn't stay dark for long. It never did. The TV's static was the first thing that found her again - thin as breath, then thickening into a wet, throat-deep hiss that made the air taste metallic. Mara's knees bumped something hard when she shifted, and the sound came back wrong, warped as if the room had already decided how loud she was allowed to be.

Cartoon Cat and Cartoon Dog sat where the light flickered through them, two smeared silhouettes in the black, their heads angled toward the screen like they were listening for a cue only they understood. She couldn't see their eyes, but she could feel the attention. The static kept stuttering, and each stutter dragged a ghost of Stitch across the glass - never fully there, always almost. In the reflection, his shape moved the way a glitch moves: too smooth to be human, too wrong to be a recording.

Mara tasted burnt plastic on her tongue and realized she'd been holding her breath. She let it out in a shaky exhale and the air warmed against her lips, as if the TV were breathing in the dark. Her hand hovered near the screen before she could stop herself, fingers splayed like she could smooth the interference. The glass was cold. The space behind it wasn't.

"Stitch?" Her voice came out small, snagging on the hiss.

Cartoon Cat twitched. Cartoon Dog's outline sharpened for a blink, then smeared again when the static surged. On the screen, a living room rearranged itself without moving - furniture that should've been solid looked stitched into place, warped around invisible seams. Somewhere in that warped living room, Stitch was alone, grinning like he'd been waiting for Mara to notice the angle.

Mara grabbed for the one thing she could control: the reflection. If he was behind the glass, then he was behind it. If she could confirm it, she could plan around it - get past the TV, find the hallway she'd seen in flashes, stop letting the tape decide which way reality faced.

She leaned closer, forehead nearly touching the screen. The static pulsed, and her breath fogged the glass in a crescent. The reflection of her face wavered, then snapped into something else - her own eyes replaced by two darker ovals that didn't blink.

Stitch's grin appeared in the reflection before it appeared in the room.

He wasn't standing anywhere she could point to. He was there anyway, reflected in the TV like a predator trapped on the wrong side. The angle made it worse; his head wasn't centered the way a mirror should line up. His eyes tracked her movement with a delay that felt like chewing.

Mara jerked back, shoulder striking the wall. The wall didn't feel like drywall. It felt like old tape - sticky in places, rough in others - stuck to itself and to her skin with a residue that smelled faintly sweet and rotten. She wiped her palm on her pants and the smear came away black and glossy.

"Okay," she whispered, not sure if she was telling herself or the room. "Okay. So you're there."

The static answered by flipping the image. The TV didn't just show the living room now; it showed her position. Her reflection shifted as if the screen had become a camera pointed back at her. Cartoon Cat and Cartoon Dog blurred at the edges, like the room's attention was being dragged toward the glass.

Mara's gaze flicked from the screen to the dark behind her, searching for a doorway that might've been hiding in the black - some seam, some gap, something the tape hadn't fully stitched shut. She remembered the black flickering doorway from the staircase bottom, the way it had felt like stepping into a screen. She remembered the staircase replaced. She remembered how fast the world could lie.

Her boot brushed something on the floor: a frayed strip of tape, warm to the touch. It dangled where it shouldn't have been, as if it had been waiting for her to step on it. She snatched it between her fingers and felt the residue smear across her skin, slick and cold at the same time.

The tape strip tugged.

Not like a pull from gravity - like a hand testing the strength of a knot. It drew her attention toward the TV without moving her body. The static hiss deepened, and the reflected Stitch leaned forward as if he'd been tugged too.

Mara tightened her grip. "No," she said, and the word came out rougher than she meant. She tried to pull the tape strip back toward herself, away from the screen, away from the reflection that was acting like a door.

The room lurched.

For a single blink, she was sure the TV had rotated. The picture didn't change smoothly; it tore. The living room in the reflection stretched, then snapped, and the black behind the screen became a tunnel of sickly yellow light. The hiss shifted into a sharper sound - like a tape being rewound too fast, like plastic grinding against plastic.

Cartoon Cat and Cartoon Dog stood abruptly, their shapes no longer content to be silhouettes. Their bodies seemed to stretch toward the TV, not walking so much as being dragged by the same invisible tug. Their heads angled at her with the wrong kind of curiosity.

Mara tried to take a step back from the screen, but the floor under her heel wasn't floor anymore. It was a slick, moving surface, yellowed and damp, like the hallway from the last flickers finally decided to become real. She felt the texture change through her shoe and up into her bones. Wood gave way to something stitched. The air smelled like old popcorn and warm metal.

The hallway carried her without asking permission.

Her fingers still clamped around the frayed strip of tape. The warm residue smeared across her palm and her wrist, and the tape tightened with every second as if it wanted to be wrapped around the world. The sickly yellow light surged at the edges of her vision, bleaching the black room out of existence.

“Stop!” she tried to shout, but the hallway swallowed the sound. Her voice came out flatter, like it had been recorded and played back through a broken speaker.

She stumbled into motion that wasn’t quite her own. The corridor stretched ahead of her, narrow enough to make her shoulders brush the walls. The walls weren’t smooth; they were stitched together in panels that didn’t align. Every time she tried to turn her head, the yellow light flickered and the angle of her reflection shifted, like the tape was refusing to let her see where she was relative to the TV anymore.

The TV was still behind her in the reflection. She could feel it. She could feel Stitch behind the glass, even when the screen itself wasn’t in view. The static hiss returned as a presence at the back of her skull.

Cartoon Cat and Cartoon Dog stopped moving. Their silhouettes held for one unnatural moment at the edge of the hallway’s yellow glow, then smeared into the walls as if the hallway had eaten them. Mara didn’t have time to wonder if they were gone or just folded into the texture.

She ran anyway.

The hallway made running feel heavy. Her feet slapped against something that sounded like damp paper. The air grew warmer, suffocating in thin layers that smelled like vinyl and sweat. The sickly yellow light flickered with each step, strobing just enough to make her stomach twist.

In the corner of her vision, the reflection in a glossy patch of wall - some impossible shine - caught Stitch again. He was closer now. Not behind her, not far away. He was in the reflection like a thought that refused to die.

Mara whipped around, tape strip snapping against her skin.

The hallway behind her looked the same - yellow, narrow, stitched panels - but the reflection on the wall was wrong. Stitch's crawling body filled it, stretched low and forward, his limbs folded in impossible angles. His grin didn't belong to a body that could move like that; it belonged to a recorded still that had learned how to breathe.

He wasn't sprinting. He was creeping, and the creeping felt deliberate, like he'd chosen the speed her fear could keep up with. His eyes flickered between animated and lifelike, each blink delayed by a fraction that made it feel like he was counting her steps.

Mara's throat tightened. "You're not - " She swallowed the rest of the sentence. She didn't know what she was trying to deny. The tape had already proven it could lie about space.

The hallway ahead of her flickered.

The sickly yellow light broke into frames. For a heartbeat, she saw the corridor as a factory belt, conveyor lights stuttering through the same stitched panels. Then it snapped back into the hallway and the stutter sound returned, sharper, angrier. The floor under her feet buckled like a reel slipping out of sync.

The reflection on the wall rippled.

Stitch's tongue - dark, elongated, too glossy - slid across the reflection like a cable searching for a socket. It pressed against the surface of the wall from the inside, leaving a wet streak that glimmered even in the yellow light. The movement wasn't just in the reflection; her skin prickled as if the tongue had brushed her face.

Mara stumbled back, trying to put distance between herself and the angle. She turned so quickly her shoulder slammed the wall again. The tape strip jerked hard in her hand, pulling her toward the direction the reflection wanted.

She realized the goal she'd been chasing - confirming whether Stitch was behind her in the reflection - had already been answered. The confirmation wasn't information. It was a trap.

The hallway snapped into a new perspective.

The walls tilted, not physically but in the way the world's logic tilted when the tape cut. Her running stance became wrong; her body felt out of alignment with her own shadow. Mara's stomach dropped. The corridor lengthened and shortened at the same time, like the tape was trying to fit her into a frame that didn't match her shape.

A faint static crackle bloomed behind her again, and this time it wasn't coming from the TV. It was coming from the air near her face, the way a camera hums when it's about to focus.

Mara lifted her hands to steady herself - - and the hallway answered by turning her movement into a pivot, forcing her to face forward. The yellow light at the end of the corridor sharpened. Something like a lens glinted in the flicker, not attached to any camera she could see, but behaving like one. The air around it felt denser, thick with interference.

The camera was her.

The thought hit her with sick clarity: the perspective wasn't tracking her anymore. It was being aimed. The corridor had become an eye, and she was the target inside the frame.

Her breath came fast and thin. "No - " She tried to back away from the lens, tried to angle her body so the reflection couldn't find her, tried to break the alignment.

The frayed strip of tape in her hand tightened until it hurt. The residue burned cold against her palm. The hallway walls seemed to close by a fraction, enough to make her shoulders scrape. The lens-glint brightened, and the static hiss thickened into a dark wet hush that swallowed every other sound.

Stitch's crawling body appeared again in the only place it could now: the reflection in the glossy patch of wall directly ahead, right in line with the lens. His grin stretched wider, teeth flashing for an instant like jagged cut film. Then his tongue unfurled out of the reflection with a slow, hungry certainty.

Mara threw her arm up, not thinking - just reacting. She pressed her palm against the wall as if she could smear the glitch away. The tongue touched the space where her hand had been a blink ago.

It didn't just reach. It wrapped.

The tip of Stitch's tongue latched onto the lens-glint's edge, and the entire corridor's flicker synchronized with the contact. Static exploded into white noise. The yellow light stuttered into frames of the warped living room from the TV - Stitch alone in a dark empty room, grinning - and then it was gone, replaced by the hallway again, tighter.

Mara tried to yank the tape strip free, tried to break whatever tether had been formed between her and the perspective. The tape didn't come. It felt anchored, warm, as if Stitch had threaded it through the frame and tied it to her fear.

Her vision blurred at the edges. The lens-glint pulled focus on her hand, on her skin, on the residue. The corridor stopped moving like a hallway and started behaving like a screen.

Cartoon Cat and Cartoon Dog were nowhere now. The only witnesses left were the flicker, the static, and Stitch's crawling grin, closer than it should've been.

Mara's stomach clenched as the tongue tightened around the lens, stretching the world's perspective until it felt like her bones were becoming part of the playback. The hallway's sickly yellow light flooded her eyes. The air smelled like burning vinyl.

The last thing she managed to do before the picture locked was shove the frayed tape strip toward the lens, as if the tape could become a wedge, as if the warm residue could make the frame slip.

The corridor shuddered.

The static snapped into a clean, sharp cut - like a tape being torn - then flooded back in with a new, harsher angle, resetting her position without permission. Mara

stumbled forward into the same yellow hallway, but the reflection was gone for a moment, leaving only the hiss and the taste of black residue.

Somewhere behind the flicker, Stitch's laughter crawled toward the lens again, patient as rewind.



Seven Days Whisper, Meadow Ends

The static didn't stop; it just changed its mouth. Mara's camera strap was between Stitch's teeth - just a fraction of fabric, just enough to drag - but the rest of her grip went slick and wrong as something wet pressed against the lens from the inside of the screen. Stitch's tongue slid through the reflection like a bookmark pulled out of a book that was still writing itself. The yellow hallway around her buckled with a stuttering frame-rate, and the taste of black residue hit her tongue like pennies left out in rain.

"Mara," Stitch's laughter whispered from somewhere too close to be sound. It wasn't in the air. It was in the glass.

She jerked back anyway. The hallway snapped tighter, the walls leaning in with that familiar analog wrongness - woodgrain turning to stitched board, corners smudging into seams. Her hand found the frayed strip of tape dangling from the clock mechanism she'd nearly escaped before, warm to the touch, residue clinging under her nails. The tape didn't feel like paper anymore. It felt like skin that had forgotten how to heal. She yanked it free, expecting friction, expecting resistance, and got a soft give, like pulling thread from a wound.

The meadow arrived like a lie that couldn't hold its shape.

Sunlight spread across grass so green it looked painted. The air smelled clean - cut stems, distant salt, the faint sweetness of something blooming too fast. For half a second, Mara blinked and believed she'd finally stepped out of the hallway's teeth. Her boots sank into real-looking earth with a weight that steadied her ribs. The camera strap dangled loose in her fist, freed from Stitch's mouth, and she held it up like proof.

"Okay," she said, and her voice came out too thin in the bright open space. "Okay. Meadow. Calm. Just - "

Just keep the tape from concluding.

That was what she wanted, plain and immediate, like a handhold. She wanted the loop to break at the edge of something gentle. She wanted to reach whatever the meadow was offering - birdsong, wind through grass, a horizon that didn't glitch into a dark room. She wanted to keep the tape from turning her into its next frame.

Behind her, the static made a sound like someone turning a dial with careful fingers.

Mara turned anyway.

Stitch stood alone in the meadow, where the sunlight should've made him crisp. He didn't cast a normal shadow. His outline shimmered at the edges, as if the light couldn't decide where to place him. His grin was too wide for his face, cartoon-bright and stitched-dark at the same time, and his eyes flicked between animated sparkle and something that looked painfully alive. He wasn't moving toward her like a creature. He was presenting himself like a broadcast.

The warm grass rippled under an invisible pressure, and the meadow's calm faltered into a series of quick rewinds. The blades of grass shivered backward. The sunlight stuttered, then reappeared, like the tape was searching for the right frame where she'd accept it.

Mara raised the frayed tape strip, the residue under her thumb smeared and tacky, and she tried to force the moment to hold. The camera in her other hand suddenly felt heavier, as if the tape wanted it as an anchor. She could almost hear the VHS hiss aligning itself, searching for the next cut.

Stitch tilted his head. His mouth opened without sound, and the tongue that had tried to wrap her camera strap unfurled again - thin, wet, stitched together at the seams, too long for his body. It didn't touch her; it hovered toward her like a question.

Mara stepped back. Her heel sank into a slightly softer patch of ground, and for an instant she felt something beneath the grass - wood boards, threaded seams, a moving floor trying to remember it was meant to carry her elsewhere. The meadow wasn't stable. It was a memory layer laid over a trap.

"Stop," she said, and hated how small it sounded.

Stitch's laughter came anyway, bright and wrong, and it carried a rhythm that didn't belong in wind or sunlight. It was counting, though nothing on the grass showed numbers. The sound slid into her ears the way the black residue had earlier, spreading warmth across her teeth until she could feel it thinking.

Mara looked down at the tape strip in her hand. The frayed edge quivered, and tiny black flecks crawled along it like static dust finding a route. As she watched, the residue made a shape - an almost-straight line, then a curve, then a smear that resolved into something like handwriting. Not letters she could read. Not symbols she could name. But the pressure in her chest understood it.

Seven.

She didn't know how she knew. She just did, the way a song gets stuck in your head even when you didn't hear the whole thing.

Her goal shifted in the middle of that realization. It wasn't enough to reach calm and hope it saved her. Stitch had put the meadow there like bait, like a final frame meant to lull her into letting the tape finish. If the "Seven days" countdown was real - if it was the controlling structure - then she needed to break the ending before it could lock.

But how do you fight a tape's last frame when it's already playing inside your hands?

She tried anyway.

Mara turned her wrist, bringing the frayed strip closer to the camera lens, and she dug in her nails until it hurt, scraping residue off the tape and smearing it across the

glass. The analog grain thickened, and the meadow's sunlight wavered as if someone had dragged a thumb across the screen. Her breath came fast, tasting of metal and cut grass.

Stitch's tongue snapped forward - still not quite touching, but close enough that her skin prickled with wet heat. The air smelled suddenly sour, like old VHS plastic warmed too long. The meadow's green drained a shade darker, and the horizon line began to crawl inward.

"No," Mara said, and forced herself to step sideways, away from whatever invisible pull was drawing her toward Stitch's mouth. Her boots brushed the grass, and the ground answered by turning grainy underfoot, grass texture smearing into stitched board.

She could feel the meadow flipping behind the eyes - like a switch being thrown. The sunlight dimmed to a pale glare. Birdsong became a thin hiss. The wind sounded like someone shuffling a stack of old tapes.

Stitch watched her with that awful patience, and his grin widened as if she'd followed the script exactly.

"Mara," he said, not with a voice, but with a glitch that shaped her name out of static. "Seven..."

Her heart stuttered. She'd heard that countdown implied before, tucked into laughter and warped audio, but hearing the number formed like that - clean enough to be meant - made her stomach drop. The tape wasn't just using her fear. It had a structure. It had a finish line.

Stitch moved then, finally moving like a creature. Not a sprint. Not a lunge. He simply stepped closer, and the meadow stepped with him, shrinking the distance between them as if the space itself was rewinding to where the tongue could wrap around the next object.

Mara's fingers tightened around the camera. The strap scraped her palm. The warm grass under her heel went soft, then firm again, like something breathing through the floor. She looked back toward where she'd entered the meadow, but the horizon wasn't a path. It was a painted edge, already starting to tear.

She made her decision with the panic still in her throat.

She threw the frayed tape strip.

Not at Stitch - because she didn't think it would reach him. Not as a weapon. She tossed it toward the brightest patch of sunlight, the place the meadow seemed most solid, and she watched it arc through the air like a strip of dead film.

For a blink, it landed and stuck to the grass, warm residue blooming against green. The sunlight flared. The meadow held.

Mara ran.

Her boots pounded the grass, and each step felt like it was being recorded at the wrong speed. The wind hissed louder, and the air grew cooler, as if the tape was turning up contrast. Behind her, Stitch's laughter didn't chase. It organized. It found the timing. It made sure she never got far enough to escape the last frame.

As she reached the brightest spot, the grass under the frayed strip began to unravel.

Threaded seams showed through like veins under skin. The meadow floor split into stitched boards that rose in ridges, guiding her forward whether she wanted it or not. The camera in her hand jerked as if pulled by an invisible tether. Mara fought it, shoulders burning, but the world insisted on aligning her with Stitch's plan.

The light overhead flickered, and the sky texture broke into VHS noise. Sunbeams became streaks of static. The birdsong turned into a thin, warped melody - Aloha   e, but broken, stretched, and chewed by tape hiss. It wasn't meant to be sung. It was meant to be used.

Mara stopped dead, breath snagging.

Ahead, where the meadow should've opened into a quiet end, Stitch's stitched monstrosity unfolded.

Not a full transformation like a costume changing. It was more like the scene was being edited into a worse version of itself. His head separated from his neck with a wet, elastic pull that made Mara's stomach clench. The detached portion didn't fall; it hovered, grin intact, eyes flickering between cartoon and something that looked like it had been watching her all along. Stitch's body stitched itself wrong around the edges, seams tightening into new shapes - too many angles, too much density, fur and thread fused into a mass that promised "Seven days" without saying it in words.

The promise arrived anyway, in the tape's warped audio, layered over the meadow's calm like rot over perfume.

"Seven days," Stitch's voice said - clean and satisfied - while the detached head tilted toward Mara and the tongue rolled like a cord searching for a plug.

Mara backed away until her calf hit a ridge of stitched board. The ground under the grass flexed. It wanted her to step closer, wanted her to complete the loop with her own movement. Her mind flashed through every moment she'd tried to fight the hallway, the staircase, the reflection - every reset that had stolen her progress and repositioned her without permission. The tape wasn't improvising. It was enforcing.

This time, though, she wasn't just scared.

She was angry.

She pressed the camera lens hard against the frayed strip's residue where it had stuck in the sunlight. The black residue smudged across the glass, and the image on the camera screen - if it was still a screen - flooded with static. The meadow's green boiled into grain. Stitch's monstrosity stuttered in place, head hovering, grin widening, tongue twitching like it was losing sync.

For one heartbeat, the world threatened to break.

Then the tape corrected itself.

A corrupted overlay of Aloha 𐀀 slid in, warped and distorted, the melody turning into something like laughter in a throat full of static. The sunlight snapped back to its earlier brightness. The stitched ridges smoothed into grass again, pretending nothing had happened. Stitch's head reattached wrong, snapping into place with a wet click that made Mara flinch. His grin sharpened, and his eyes flickered between animated sparkle and that lifelike hunger once more.

"Seven," Stitch whispered, and the word felt like a countdown button being pressed inside the tape.

Mara's breath came out in a broken sound. Her hands shook around the camera. She couldn't tell if she'd stopped the ending or if the tape had simply advanced to the next segment - resetting while keeping the same promise.

The meadow's calm held for a moment longer, too perfect, too bright. Then the grass texture began to crawl, as if the surface was being peeled back to show stitched boards beneath. The horizon line tore open into a strip of static, and the air filled with that wet, dark hush that meant the VHS was about to swallow the scene whole.

Mara watched Stitch step forward into the light as if he belonged there, as if the meadow was his living room and she was just another frame he'd laid out.

Seven days had been confirmed.

And the tape didn't end - it restarted, already chewing on the next version of her calm.

The corrupted Aloha 𐀀 overlay returned, louder and more wrong, until the melody sounded like tape warping under tension. Stitch's laughter slid under it, patient as rewind, and the meadow dissolved into static so thoroughly that even her anger couldn't keep a shape.

In the final smear of sun and grain, Mara saw the frayed tape strip in the grass again - warm, dangling residue intact - like it had never been thrown at all.

Then the screen cut.

About the Author

12matt3r

[Http://doesntmatter.us](http://doesntmatter.us)

The Stitch Tape

by Hungry Shmorez

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